



Discussion Guide: Brent Strawn

The Greatest Story Never Told: Rethinking the Bible as Poetry

Reflect

- We often talk about the Bible as a narrative – that is, a big, unified story from cover to cover. What are some of the advantages of seeing the Bible in this way? What are some of problems with this view?
- Which parts of Brent's case for re-thinking the Bible as poetry do you find most convincing? What sort of questions does it raise for you about the nature of scripture?

Respond

- Brent proposes four "merits" that come from seeing the Bible as poetry: Candor, Contradiction, Contemporaneity, and Continuation. How might these poetic features help you understand some of the tricky parts of the Bible (e.g., the violent conquest of Canaan in Joshua; variety among the four Gospels; faith vs. deeds in the New Testament letters)?
- There's a common slogan (occasionally found on billboards and bumper stickers) that says: "The Bible Says It, That Settles It!" What would you affirm about this statement and what it assumes about how the Bible works? What do you find problematic about it? In light of what you learned from Brent's talk, how would you respond to someone who fully affirmed this slogan?
- Like a poem, there is always more to discover in the Bible. In your experience, what is one passage of scripture that continues to generate new insights and meaning each time you have come back around to it? What new insights have you gleaned about this passage along the way?

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